

REGAL REPRESENTATIVES

Blue-blooded men and women who will bring royal flair to the House of the People



▲ CHHATRAPATI SHAHU SHAHAJI, *76*

| CONGRESS | *Kolhapur, Maharashtra*

Assets worth Rs 342 crore, a 1936 Maybach and a 1962 Merc in his fleet of vintage cars, and yet a "commoner among royals"! That is indeed the moniker his connect with the masses has fetched this Kolhapur royal and 12th descendant of the Maratha warrior Shivaji Maharaj. 'Mothe Maharaj', as he is also called, had joined the Shiv Sena in the 1990s, but refrained from dipping his toes in electoral waters. He was content instead to let his sons dabble in politics while he devoted himself to numerous educational institutes and charitable trusts. Till the Congress persuaded him to contest the Kolhapur seat, he obliged, and tasted success in his maiden parliamentary foray. Now in the lower house, the upper crust royal should bring some welcome gravitas to parliamentary proceedings.

YADUVEER KRISHNADATTA CHAMARAJA WADIYAR, *32* ▶

| BJP | *Mysore, Karnataka*

A guitar-playing, rock, blues, jazz-loving Maharaja? See him in royal regalia, presiding solemnly over the Mysore Dasara, and you may find it hard to reconcile the two avatars. But then that's the 27th custodian of the 600-year-old Wadiyar dynasty, adopted by the childless widow of Srikantadatta Wadiyar, who died without naming an heir. Yaduveer was anointed Maharaja of Mysuru in May 2015 amid much fanfare and some controversy. Royal duties apart, he is now also tracing his predecessor's political footsteps—Srikantadatta was a four-term Congress MP from Mysore—though this royalty's loyalties lean more rightwards. A graduate of the University of Massachusetts, Yaduveer is married to fellow royal Trishika of Rajasthan's Dungarpur family. Strange fact? The maharaja has assets worth Rs 9.47 crore, but does not own a car.

MAHIMA KUMARI MEWAR, *52* ▶

| BJP | *Rajsamand, Rajasthan*

You may be born into royalty, but that may not shield you from the barbs of commoners. And it was charges of nepotism this royal of Mewar had to contend with, given that her husband Vishvaraj Singh was elected to the state assembly just six months back. But then if you are a humble, approachable leader, people reward you—in her case, a margin of 392,223 votes, the highest in the state. Vindication enough for this Psychology grad from LSR.

